



SMARTPHONE MID-RANGE

PUSHING THE BOUNDARIES OF
PERFORMANCE ON A BUDGET

This year, the mid-range phones (10K-20K) also pushed the boundaries of pure performance. While we saw phones stride into high-end territory with 6GB RAM and 128GB storage, OEMs attempted to stand out with software trickery. AI and ML were two running themes throughout the year.

While that did not necessarily guarantee better performance, new, more powerful chipsets pushed the performance benchmark higher. Things like dual cameras and notched displays became more common and glass was the material of choice for the design. In the mid-range segment, it's all about who is compromising the least to keep the costs in check.

The trick to choose the best mid-range phone came down to figuring out who is offering the fastest performance as well as features to make use of that. Here are our results.

2018 ZERO1 AWARD WINNER Xiaomi Mi A2

Xiaomi's second-generation Android One smartphone feels refined, comfortable and can take the best photos among its peers. It's also quite fast and powerful under the hood, 23 percent more than last year's winner to be precise. It outscored all other mid-range phones in our performance tests, but not by a huge margin though. Since the phone's software is handled by Google, updates are more or less guaranteed for the next two years. The display on the Mi A2 is also visibly better than most other mid-rangers we tested. The phone's raison d'être is the rear camera that can produce the best images among other mid-range phones. It relies on pixel binning to improve photos, something that only expensive flagships have relied upon so far. It's only Achilles heel is the not-so-impressive battery life, but with fast charging on offer, that didn't become much of a hassle.



Xiaomi Mi A2

Price: ₹18,999



RUNNER UP Honor 8X

The EMUI interface is not the best-looking UI out there, but the Honor 8X more than makes up for it with raw performance that is just one percent less than the Xiaomi Mi A2. The Honor 8X also outperformed most other mid-range phones launched this year on benchmarks, save for the graphics tests. But there too, the Honor 8X compensates with AI-powered GPU acceleration that makes select popular games run much smoother. The Kirin 710's AI capabilities are used primarily in the camera that isn't all that reliable, but given good lighting, it can take decently good photos. Save for the aggressive RAM management and an inconsistent camera, this year's runners-up in the mid-range segment offers reliable performance without burning a hole in your pocket.



Honor 8X

Price: ₹16,999



Asus Zenfone Max Pro M1

Price: ₹14,999

BEST BUY Asus Zenfone Max Pro M1

The Asus Zenfone Max Pro M1 offers everything that the Xiaomi Redmi Note 5 Pro offers, but at a lesser price. It's value proposition, as a result is much higher and even on our performance tests, the Zenfone Max Pro M1 came out higher than Xiaomi's popular Redmi Note 5 Pro. That's primarily because of the giant 5,000mAh battery that gave a screen-on time of ten hours which is trumped only by the Nokia 7 Plus which is more expensive. The 16+5MP dual rear camera is a tad underwhelming in front of other, more capable smartphones and the design isn't the most noticeable. The phone has been an underdog in the smartphone market but well-optimised performance combined with a stock Android interface and a humongous 5,000mAh battery makes Asus' mid-ranger an easy one to recommend.